

Law of Prägnanz (Simplicity)

What is it?

People interpret complex visuals in the simplest form possible.
The brain reduces complicated shapes into clear, familiar structures.

History

Originates from Gestalt psychology research around **1912**, which showed that the mind naturally organizes visual information into simple and meaningful patterns.

The Psychology Behind It

- Brain prefers patterns that demand less effort
- Simplified shapes are easier to remember
- Reducing complexity lowers cognitive load
- Visual grouping forms clearer understanding

Why It Matters

- Can overly simplify meaning
- Can remove nuance
- May reduce creative expression
- Can limit depth in interpretation

How to Apply It

- Use simple geometric shapes in icons
- Organize layouts logically
- Maintain minimal, clutter-free design
- Keep strong repetition in structure
- Apply clear hierarchy and prioritization
- Balance simplicity with necessary context

Theory in Action

- Apple products rely on clean visuals and minimal complexity to match the brain's preference for simplicity
- The Olympic logo uses five simple circles to represent a global, unified message

Final Thought

The brain loves simplicity.

Design should lean into that — simplifying complex ideas without stripping away meaning.